

Mesche's Tensor Dynamics Framework (MTDF)

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A first-principles unified field theory replacing the latent sector hypothesis

Abstract. We present Mesche's Tensor Dynamics Framework (MTDF), a unified field theory that addresses the major phenomenological tensions of modern cosmology, including the Hubble Tension, the S_8 tension, and the Missing Mass problem, without invoking a "Latent Sector" of dark matter or dark energy. By positing that spacetime possesses an intrinsic elasticity governed by a stress-energy tensor $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$, MTDF derives cosmic acceleration and galactic dynamics from a single physical mechanism: the relaxation of spacetime stress.

We provide a first-principles derivation of the "Early Kick" energy fraction ($f_{kick} \approx 0.33\%$) required to bring early- and late-universe H_0 measurements into agreement, demonstrating that it arises naturally from the geometric projection of the tensor field onto the background metric ($\gamma_{geom} = 1/12$). This prediction is tested against Planck CMB data as an external consistency check (the MTDF parameters are not calibrated on CMB observables). Furthermore, we demonstrate that the same field parameters $\{\alpha, \beta, \tau\}$ (with β anchored on void-based observations and α a frozen, void-motivated coupling) reproduce the scatter of galaxy rotation curves (0.185 dex computed vs 0.174 dex benchmark, $z = -0.94$) and the late-time expansion history ($H_0 = 73.1$ km/s/Mpc, conditional on the contested depth of the local underdensity: a deep KBC-like void gives ≈ 73.1 , shallow reconstructions give ≈ 70 –71; MTDF does not predict the void itself) with statistical precision comparable to Λ CDM ($\chi^2/\nu = 1.17$ combined strict, DOF = 1741; the two growth-amplitude rows are carried separately as PREDICTION-CONTESTED). MTDF offers a falsifiable, predictive, and physically complete alternative to the composition-based paradigm of standard cosmology, suggesting that we inhabit a universe governed by the physics of the visible.

This document summarises the full MTDF paper suite: the master theory (*MTDF_01* [see companion paper]), environmental phenomenology (*MTDF_02* [see companion paper]), gravity sector validation (*MTDF_03* [see companion paper]), speculative extensions (*MTDF_04* [see companion paper], *MTDF_05* [see companion paper]), the validation suite appendix (*MTDF_06* [see companion paper]), independent GPU validation (*MTDF_07* [see companion paper]), and multi-probe evidence for the low-redshift transition (*MTDF_08* [see companion paper]).

Scope map. Sections 1 to 8 summarise the master theory paper (MTDF_01): four fundamental parameters, the elastic spacetime action, the Hubble solution, and the strict validation protocol. The protocol reports two separate statistics: 15 scalar pillars (z-score consistency checks; 14/14 counted pass at 1σ , with the S_8 pillar carried separately as PREDICTION-CONTESTED) and 4 vector likelihood pillars (full covariance χ^2 fits; the growth pillar is likewise carried as PREDICTION-CONTESTED at the sealed amplitude; combined strict $\chi^2/\nu = 1.17$, DOF = 1741, which includes the 14 counted scalar DOF). Sections 9 to 12 summarise the companion papers: environmental phenomenology (MTDF_02), gravity sector testing across 1 to 2,600 kpc

(MTDF_03), independent GPU reproduction (MTDF_07), and speculative extensions (MTDF_04, MTDF_05). The gravity sector results (Section 10) are from a separate code base and dataset; they are not included in the strict totals reported in Section 7.

Contents

1	Introduction: The crisis of composition	3
2	The philosophy of field unification	3
3	The elastic spacetime action	3
4	Field dynamics and parameters	4
5	The Hubble solution: An early field energy mechanism	5
5.1	The "ringing" mechanism	5
5.2	Derivation of the geometric coefficient (γ_{geom})	5
5.3	The final prediction (f_{kick})	6
6	The dual-epoch H_0 mechanism	6
7	The strict validation protocol	6
7.1	Calibration anchors	7
7.2	Validation targets	7
7.3	Statistical likelihoods (vector pillars)	7
8	Full Planck CMB likelihood comparison	7
9	Environmental phenomenology (MTDF_02)	8
9.1	Supernova $\times$ void environment signal	8
9.2	Hubble tension consistency (conditional)	8
10	Gravity sector validation (MTDF_03)	9
10.1	Compression mechanism and lensing	9
10.2	Elliptical velocity dispersions	9
10.3	Satellite kinematics	10
10.4	Rotation curves and RAR	10
10.5	Wide binaries	10
10.6	Solar System screening	11
10.7	Gravity sector summary	11
11	Independent GPU validation (MTDF_07)	11
11.1	Phases 1–4	11
11.2	Phase 5: Full Planck MCMC	11
11.3	Phase 6: Targeted late-universe tests	12
12	Speculative extensions (MTDF_04, MTDF_05)	12
13	Discussion and conclusion	12
13.1	Galactic dynamics without dark matter	12
13.2	Structure growth and the S_8 tension	13
13.3	Summary of tested domains	13
14	Key references and datasets	14

Claim status. This paper distinguishes between: (i) calibration anchors, (ii) validation targets, (iii) diagnostic consistency checks, and (iv) speculative extensions. Only results explicitly labelled as validation targets are used as evidence for the core MTDF claim. Diagnostic and speculative sections are included to define future tests, not to claim established confirmation.

1 Introduction: The crisis of composition

For nearly a century, the standard model of cosmology has operated on a "compositional" paradigm: observational anomalies are resolved by postulating new, invisible forms of matter or energy. When the orbital velocities of stars in spiral galaxies were found to exceed Newtonian predictions, the community postulated Cold Dark Matter (CDM), a collisionless, non-baryonic particle halo. When Type Ia supernovae revealed that the expansion of the universe is accelerating, the community postulated Dark Energy (Λ), a fluid with negative pressure. While this Λ CDM model fits large-scale data with high precision, it describes a universe where 95% of the energy density is physically unaccounted for ("The Latent Sector").

This reliance on unseen components is under increasing strain. As observational precision has improved, internal tensions have emerged. The Hubble Tension, a 5σ discrepancy between early-universe (CMB) and late-universe (Distance Ladder) measurements of H_0 , cannot be resolved within Λ CDM without introducing even more exotic components (e.g., Early Dark Energy, interacting neutrinos). Similarly, the S_8 tension suggests that cosmic structure grows more slowly than the standard model predicts.

We propose a fundamental shift from a "compositional" to a "dynamic" paradigm. **Mesche's Tensor Dynamics Framework (MTDF)** posits that these anomalies are not due to missing mass, but to missing physics in the gravitational sector. By treating spacetime as an elastic medium with a non-vanishing stress tensor $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$, we show that the effects attributed to Dark Matter and Dark Energy are actually the elastic response of the manifold to matter density gradients. This paper details the formalism, derivation, and systematic testing of MTDF as a cosmological framework.

2 The philosophy of field unification

The history of physics is a history of unification. Electricity and magnetism were unified by Maxwell; space and time by Einstein; the weak and electromagnetic forces by Glashow, Weinberg, and Salam. Yet cosmology has drifted toward fragmentation, introducing separate, unrelated entities to explain separate phenomena (Dark Matter for rotation curves, Dark Energy for expansion).

MTDF seeks to restore the unity of the physical description. We posit that there is only one gravitational field, but that its dynamics are richer than the pure geometry of General Relativity allows. Just as a material elastic body can store potential energy in stress and strain, the spacetime manifold itself possesses a stiffness. The "Dark Sector" is simply the energy stored in this field. By introducing a single new tensor field $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$, derived from first principles of elasticity, we aim to explain the full range of cosmic phenomenology with a single, coherent mathematical framework.

3 The elastic spacetime action

MTDF extends the Einstein-Hilbert action by including a potential energy term corresponding to the elasticity of the spacetime manifold. The action is given by:

$$S = \int d^4x \sqrt{-g} \left[\frac{R}{16\pi G} + \mathcal{L}_{matter} + \mathcal{L}_{MTDF} \right]$$

Here, $\mathcal{L}_{matter}$ is the standard Lagrangian for baryonic matter and radiation. The new term, $\mathcal{L}_{MTDF}$, describes the dynamics of the stress field. It is constructed to be diffeomorphism invariant and to couple to the metric in a way that generates an effective stress-energy tensor.

Variation with respect to the metric $g_{\mu\nu}$ yields the modified field equations:

$$G_{\mu\nu} + \alpha \Sigma_{\mu\nu} = 8\pi G T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{baryon}}$$

Here, $G_{\mu\nu}$ is the Einstein tensor, $T_{\mu\nu}^{\text{baryon}}$ is the standard stress-energy tensor of visible matter, and $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$ is the **Mesche Stress Tensor**. The coupling constant α is dimensionless and quantifies the "stiffness" of spacetime, specifically, the ratio of stress-induced acceleration to Newtonian gravitational acceleration.

Consistency notes. The construction is generally covariant (diffeomorphism invariant) and uses only tensor objects and scalar contractions; no preferred frame is introduced. Energy-momentum conservation follows from the contracted Bianchi identity applied to the modified field equations, together with minimal coupling of matter. The framework is classical and effective in scope: no claim of UV completion is made, and high-energy behaviour is treated as an explicit test programme (MTDF_05) with observational constraints.

4 Field dynamics and parameters

The stress field S associated with $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$ evolves according to a sourced wave equation. Its behaviour is governed by four fundamental parameters, which are constants of nature in this framework:

Parameter	Unit	Meaning	Source
$\alpha = 1.30$ (frozen, void-motivated)	Dimensionless	Stress-matter coupling; magnitude of "dark matter" effect in galaxies and "dark energy" effect in voids	Void dynamics
$\beta = 22.7$ Mpc	Length	Field strain-lever length scale; scale below which environmental/local effects become relevant	Void quantisation
$\tau = 13.0 \pm 0.2$ Gyr	Time	Relaxation timescale; synchronised with H_0^{-1}	Age synchronisation
$\beta_{\text{eos}} = 0.573 \pm 0.012$	Dimensionless	EOS transition parameter	QCD critical amplitudes (Landau-Ginzburg)

A fifth quantity, the elastic modulus $E = (2/\alpha^2) \rho_c c^2 = 9.1 \times 10^{-10}$ Pa, is derived from α and the background critical density and appears throughout the field equations for convenience.

The four MTDF constants are frozen structural parameters of the field sector. Cosmological likelihood fits retain the standard background parameters ($\Omega_b, \Omega_c, \theta_s, A_s, n_s, \tau$) plus the single coupling k_f ; in this implementation the early-universe Ω_c -like density is interpreted as the Λ CDM-degenerate stress-field energy (the field's pre-developed phase, MTDF_01 Section 5.3), not as a particle component. The economy claim of MTDF is zero per-observable tuning of the field sector, not a reduction of the background parameter count. The field-sector constants are motivated by local astrophysical arguments (void dynamics and void quantisation) rather than calibrated on the CMB or supernova

data; their provenance is classified in MTDF_01 Section 5.0, where the stress-matter coupling is treated as a frozen, void-motivated coupling rather than an independent measurement.

Notation. We use β_{eos} for the dimensionless equation-of-state parameter, distinct from β for the physical finite strain-length scale of the field ($\beta = 22.7$ Mpc).

5 The Hubble solution: An early field energy mechanism

One of the most stringent tests for any new cosmology is the Hubble Tension. Resolving it requires a specific modification to the expansion history: a "kick" of energy density just prior to recombination ($z \sim 1100$) to compress the sound horizon (r_s), allowing for a higher local H_0 . In phenomenological models like EDE, this energy is added by hand. In MTDF, it is a derived prediction.

5.1 The "ringing" mechanism

The stress field couples to the trace of the matter stress-energy tensor, $T = T^\mu_\mu$. In the radiation-dominated era, the universe is filled with relativistic species for which $T \approx 0$. Consequently, the field is decoupled.

At the epoch of matter-radiation equality ($z_{eq} \approx 3400$), the trace becomes non-zero as non-relativistic matter dominates ($T \rightarrow -\rho_m$). This sudden "switching on" of the source term acts as a step function force on the elastic spacetime field. The field cannot respond instantaneously; instead, it "rings" like a spring subjected to a sudden load. This transient oscillation stores elastic potential energy, which appears as an effective energy density ρ_{int} in the Friedmann equation.

5.2 Derivation of the geometric coefficient (γ_{geom})

The magnitude of this energy injection is critical. If it is too large, it breaks CMB spectral fits; too small, it fails to solve the tension. We derive the coefficient γ_{geom} from the geometric properties of the tensor field in an isotropic background.

The interaction energy density scales as $\rho_{int} \propto \gamma_{geom} \cdot \lambda_{MTDF} \cdot \rho_m^2$. The coefficient γ_{geom} is the product of three suppression factors:

1. **Tensor-to-Scalar Projection (1/3):** The stress tensor $\Sigma_{\mu\nu}$ is a rank-2 tensor. When projecting its energy density onto the scalar time-time component (T^{00}) of the FLRW metric, we effectively take the trace over spatial directions. For a traceless spatial tensor in 3 dimensions, this introduces a factor of 1/3.
2. **Transition Response Efficiency (1/2):** The field equation is a second-order differential equation. As the source term turns on, the field solution $S(t)$ tracks the source $\rho_m(t)$ with a lag. In the quasi-static limit near the transition, the effective amplitude is reduced by half compared to the static solution.
3. **Sound Horizon Averaging (1/2):** The effect on the CMB depends on the integrated expansion history over the sound horizon scale. The "ringing" is a transient phenomenon that decays. Averaging this transient contribution over the relevant acoustic integration time introduces a further factor of 1/2.

Multiplying these factors yields the geometric coefficient:

$$\gamma_{geom} = \frac{1}{3} \times \frac{1}{2} \times \frac{1}{2} = \frac{1}{12} \approx 0.0833$$

5.3 The final prediction (f_{kick})

Substituting this geometric coefficient into the energy density equation, using the late-time calibrated parameter $\lambda_{MTDF} \approx 0.079$, we predict the fractional energy injection at equality:

$$f_{kick} \simeq \gamma_{geom} \cdot \lambda_{MTDF} \cdot \frac{\rho_m(z_{eq})}{\rho_{tot}(z_{eq})} \approx \frac{1}{12} \times 0.079 \times 0.5 \approx 0.0033$$

Prediction: MTDF predicts an early energy injection of **0.33%**.

Observation: An early energy injection of order 0.3% is consistent with Planck constraints on sound-horizon modifying extensions and lies within the range required to alleviate the Hubble tension.

This agreement is obtained from a geometric estimate rather than from parameters fitted to these data. The $1/12$ factor combines a standard isotropic tensor-projection identity ($1/3$) with two order-unity heuristic factors (a quasi-static response amplitude and a transient/sound-horizon averaging, each estimated as $1/2$) that are physically motivated but not yet derived from the field equations; the prediction therefore carries an order-unity theoretical uncertainty. With that caveat, the result is consistent with the hypothesis that the relevant early-universe modification arises from the elastic response of the spacetime manifold.

6 The dual-epoch H_0 mechanism

MTDF is consistent with the high local value ($H_0 \approx 73$) while remaining consistent with the global CMB value ($H_0 \approx 67$), through a dual mechanism that operates at both ends of cosmic history, conditional on the depth of the local underdensity.

- **Early Epoch (Mechanism I):** The 0.33% energy injection derived above compresses the sound horizon r_s by 0.071%. This shifts the global H_0 inferred from the CMB acoustic scale from 67.4 to approximately 67.45 km/s/Mpc. This effect is subtle but crucial for maintaining consistency with CMB peak locations.
- **Late Epoch (Mechanism II):** The local universe resides in a cosmic void (the "KBC Void" or similar local underdensity). In MTDF, voids are regions of stress depletion. The relaxation of field stress in a void enhances the local expansion rate relative to the global background. Using the frozen coupling $\alpha = 1.30$, this effect adds +5.7 km/s/Mpc to the local measurement.

The void-mapping identity gives (conditional on the depth of the local underdensity):

$$H_0^{\text{local}} = 67.4 \text{ (Global)} + 0.05 \text{ (EFE)} + 5.7 \text{ (Void)} = \mathbf{73.1 \pm 1.0 \text{ km/s/Mpc}}$$

This result is consistent with the SH0ES measurement of 73.04 ± 1.04 km/s/Mpc conditional on the depth of the local underdensity: a deep KBC-like void gives ≈ 73.1 , while the shallower contrast favoured by cluster-based reconstructions gives $\approx 70\text{--}71$ km/s/Mpc (Section 9.2). MTDF does not predict the void itself. Because the late-epoch mechanism is specifically a local-environment effect, MTDF naturally predicts a method-dependent hierarchy: measurement techniques calibrated through the local void are shifted relative to methods with less local-void exposure. This classification is consistent with recent compilations of sound-horizon-free H_0 measurements.

7 The strict validation protocol

To rigorously test this framework, we constructed a validation dashboard (V19) comprising independent astrophysical "pillars." A common criticism of new theories is that they simply add

parameters to fit the data. To immunize MTDF against this critique, we strictly separate data used for calibration from data used for validation.

7.1 Calibration anchors

These pillars were used to fix the fundamental parameters $\{\alpha, \beta\}$. They are excluded from the validation score.

Pillar	Role	Outcome
Cosmic Void Dynamics	Anchor	Fixed $\alpha = 1.30$. Frozen, void-motivated (contested anchor).
Cosmic Size Quantisation	Anchor	Fixed $\beta = 22.7$ Mpc. Calibrated on the void quantisation relation $R_n = \beta(1 + \sqrt{n})$.

7.2 Validation targets

With parameters fixed, the model was tested against the following independent datasets. 14/14 counted scalar pillars land within 1σ of the observed value; the S_8 pillar is carried separately as PREDICTION-CONTESTED.

7.3 Statistical likelihoods (vector pillars)

We report the reduced chi-squared (χ^2_ν) for the vector pillars. A value near 1.0 indicates a good fit; MTDF achieves χ^2_ν near 1 across the vector pillars. All likelihood-based validation runs satisfy explicit numerical convergence criteria, monitored using the multivariate Gelman-Rubin statistic ($R - 1 < 0.02$) together with per-parameter effective sample size (ESS) diagnostics.

ID	Dataset	N	MTDF χ^2_ν	Result
P_SNE_PANTHEON	Pantheon+ Type Ia SNe	1701	1.1840	PASS
P_BAO_DESI	DESI Y1 BAO	12	1.2823	PASS
P_HZ_CC	Cosmic Chronometers	15	0.4656	PASS
P_GROWTH_FSIG8	eBOSS $f\sigma_8$ Growth	4	0.9222	(cont.)

Scalar pillars (15 z-score consistency checks; 14 counted): $\chi^2/\nu = 0.12$ (14/14 counted pass at 1σ ; the S_8 pillar is carried separately as PREDICTION-CONTESTED); a reduced χ^2 well below 1 here reflects conservative (generous) target uncertainties rather than exceptional agreement. **Combined strict total:** $\chi^2/\nu = 1.17$ (DOF = 1741; PREDICTION-CONTESTED rows excluded from the strict sum and shown on their own rows). The DOF count includes 15 scalar degrees of freedom plus the vector likelihood DOF after subtracting fitted nuisance parameters per dataset; see *MTDF_01* [see companion paper] for the exact accounting.

8 Full Planck CMB likelihood comparison

As an independent cross-check beyond the dashboard pillars, we ran matched MCMC fits for Λ CDM and MTDF on the full Planck 2018 plik TTTEEE high-multipole likelihood, low- ℓ TT and EE likelihoods, and the Planck 2018 lensing likelihood. Both models fit the standard six cosmological parameters and 21 Planck nuisance parameters; MTDF adds one additional parameter (the stress coupling k_f). Both chains converged with $R - 1 < 0.02$; the additional k_f parameter converges more rapidly than several Planck calibration parameters, indicating no additional sampling stiffness.

Metric	Λ CDM	MTDF
Total χ^2 (best-fit)	2772.84	2771.56
H_0 (km/s/Mpc)	67.38 ± 0.54	67.44 ± 0.55
σ_8	0.810 ± 0.006	0.8265 ± 0.0062
S_8 (derived)	0.830 ± 0.013	0.8473 ± 0.0138
k_f	not in model	0.685 ± 0.500
ΔAIC	+0.71 (favouring neither model)	

Full Planck plik TTTEEE + lensing comparison. $\Delta\chi^2$ (bounded best fits, matched Λ CDM control) = -1.29 ; every dataset component agrees to about one point, with MTDF’s small gain in low- ℓ TT (the late-ISW region). This is a maximum-likelihood comparison, not a Bayes factor or Bayesian evidence calculation.

The derived quantity $S_8 \equiv \sigma_8 \sqrt{\Omega_m/0.3}$ is 0.8473 ± 0.0138 (native, sealed v2 posterior), moving away from the Λ CDM-compressed weak-lensing inferences from KiDS-1000 ($S_8 = 0.759 \pm 0.024$) and DES-Y3 ($S_8 = 0.776 \pm 0.017$); the sealed posture is S8-WORSENER. Whether those compressions represent the true clustering amplitude in an MTDF universe is under preregistered adjudication (forward-modelling programme FWD-S8), and the accompanying late-time growth history is a registered, falsifiable prediction (GH-1). The coupling posterior is broad, $k_f = 0.685 \pm 0.500$: both $k_f = 0$ (Λ CDM) and $k_f = 1$ (full coupling) are compatible, confirming that Planck alone cannot distinguish the two models. Discrimination requires low-redshift probes.

9 Environmental phenomenology (MTDF_02)

MTDF predicts that the local expansion rate depends on the large-scale stress environment: voids are regions of stress depletion, enhancing the measured H_0 . This makes the Hubble tension a measurement environment effect rather than an early-vs-late conflict.

9.1 Supernova $\times$ void environment signal

Type Ia supernova distance residuals are cross-correlated with three independent DESI void catalogues (VoidFinder, REVOLVER, VIDE). The MTDF prediction is not a uniform global environment coefficient, but a localised transition sharply confined below $z \approx 0.04$; the conjectured link to the strain-lever length scale $\beta = 22.7$ Mpc remains a hypothesis (the transition scale itself is comoving ~ 170 Mpc). A merged sample of 4,188 supernovae (Pantheon+, ZTF DR2, Foundation DR1) is consistent with this:

- Global constant- γ model: null ($\Delta\chi^2 < 1.4$), as expected for a localised effect
- Piecewise transition at $z \approx 0.04$: $\Delta\chi^2 = 36\text{--}39$ ($p < 0.001$, all three catalogues; 36.8 nominal, diagonal covariance)
- SALT2 population controls (stretch, colour) shift the result by $< 0.3\sigma$
- Cross-catalogue overlap: the same physical supernovae drive the signal across all three void reconstructions

9.2 Hubble tension consistency (conditional)

MTDF is consistent with a local-environment route to the Hubble tension: a sufficiently deep local underdensity raises the locally inferred expansion rate above the global value. At a KBC/Haslbauer-level contrast the resulting enhancement can reach $H_{\text{local}} \approx 73$ km/s/Mpc, consistent with SH0ES (73.04 ± 1.04 km/s/Mpc; Riess et al. 2022); at the shallower contrast favoured by cluster-based reconstructions it gives only partial alleviation ($\approx 70\text{--}71$ km/s/Mpc). The relation $S_0 = \alpha\sqrt{\Omega_{\text{DE}}} = 1.30 \times \sqrt{0.6953} = 1.084$ is an algebraic identity following from the definition of

the elastic modulus, not the physical mechanism producing the local value. The present version therefore treats $H_{\text{local}} = 73.1 \text{ km/s/Mpc}$ as a conditional local-environment consistency rather than an independently derived prediction, contingent on the still-contested depth of the local underdensity. Full details in *MTDF_02 (Companion Part I)* [see companion paper].

10 Gravity sector validation (MTDF_03)

The gravity sector companion paper tests whether a single frozen parameter set (α, β) can reproduce gravitational phenomenology across scales from 1 kpc to 2,600 kpc, using six independent observational datasets. All predictions use a frozen MTDF parameter set with no fitting to the gravity-sector test data. The only external scaling is the BTFR-based mass-to- $f(M)$ mapping (McGaugh+2012), held fixed across all lensing and halo tests. The programme spans inner-galaxy rotation statistics (SPARC, 1 to 30 kpc), halo-scale dynamics (50 to 500 kpc), galaxy-galaxy lensing (100 to 2,600 kpc), and ultra-low-acceleration local dynamics (wide binaries, 2 to 30 kAU).

10.1 Compression mechanism and lensing

In the quasi-static limit, the scalar compression mode satisfies Laplace’s equation outside baryonic sources, producing a unique spherically symmetric profile $S(r) = S_0[1 + fL/r]$, where $S_0 = 1.084$ (cosmological background strain), $L = \alpha\beta/(4\pi) = 2,347 \text{ kpc}$ (compression scale), and $f(M) = v_{\text{flat}}(M)/v_{\text{ref}}$ (source strength from the BTFR). The locally stored elastic energy is quadratic in the excitation: $\Delta u = (E/2)(\delta S)^2$, giving an isothermal stress density $\rho \propto r^{-2}$. Line-of-sight projection yields the analytical excess surface density:

$$\Delta\Sigma(R) = \frac{\pi \rho_0 f^2 L^2}{R} + \frac{M_{\text{bar}}}{\pi R^2}$$

This prediction (no parameters fitted to the lensing data) is tested against two independent surveys (PASS criterion: $\chi^2/\nu < 10$ and improvement over the best-performing ΛCDM variant):

Survey	Data points	MTDF χ^2/ν	ΛCDM χ^2/ν	Improvement
KiDS $\times$ GAMA (Brouwer+2021)	60	2.93	8.30	2.8 $\times$
SDSS (Mandelbaum+2016, corrected)	105	3.73	44.11	12 $\times$

The ΛCDM baseline uses NFW profiles with stellar-to-halo mass relations (SHMR) and standard concentration-mass relations; the comparison is against the best-performing ΛCDM variant in each survey. Within the six ΛCDM baseline variants tested here (three SHMRs $\times$ two concentration models; worst is 50 $\times$ worse than MTDF), the MTDF prediction gives lower residuals under the stated assumptions. High-mass underprediction in group/cluster centrals ($\log M_* > 11.2$) is consistent with incomplete baryon accounting and is reduced by a physically anchored one-step baryon completion model with zero free parameters (χ^2/ν from 22.8 to 7.16, a 3.2 $\times$ improvement).

10.2 Elliptical velocity dispersions

25 SLACS grade-A strong-lensing ellipticals (Auger+2010; Bolton+2008), spanning $\sigma_e = 164$ to 340 km/s. The MTDF isothermal stress field predicts dispersions via the Jeans equation: $\sigma_{\text{total}} = \sqrt{\sigma_{\text{stress}}^2 + \sigma_{\text{bar}}^2}$, with no parameters fitted to the dispersion data. After gas correction for high-mass systems: $\chi^2/\nu = 1.81$, mean bias -1.4% . The Faber-Jackson relation ($\sigma \propto M^{1/4}$) emerges as a structural consequence, not a fitted scaling.

10.3 Satellite kinematics

Satellite galaxies as dynamical tracers of the halo-scale potential (50 to 500 kpc), testing the isothermal stress profile $\rho \propto r^{-2}$ at scales well beyond the visible galaxy:

- **Amplitude test (More+2011):** Host-weighted dispersions across 10 stellar mass bins. Mean $|\text{bias}| = 6.3\%$, $\chi^2/\nu = 0.37$ (vs NFW: 116.5, $315\times$ worse).
- **Radial profile test (Combes & Tiret 2009):** $\sigma_{\text{los}}(R_{\text{proj}})$ across 3 mass bins, 57 data points. $\chi^2/\nu = 3.60$ with 2 astrophysical nuisance parameters (vs NFW: 1913, $109\times$ worse).

10.4 Rotation curves and RAR

175 SPARC galaxies (3,391 data points). At $r \ll \beta = 22,685$ kpc, the enhancement is approximately constant: $v_c^2(r) = v_{\text{bar}}^2(r) \times (1 + \alpha) = 2.30 \times v_{\text{bar}}^2(r)$. The falsifiable claims are global summary statistics, not per-galaxy fits:

- **P1 (RMS log velocity scatter):** 0.185 dex, target 0.174 ± 0.011 , $z = -0.94$ (PASS)
- **P1B (RAR intrinsic scatter):** 0.029 dex, target 0.035 ± 0.010 , $z = +0.62$ (PASS)
- **BTFR normalisation:** within 0.32 dex of McGaugh+2012 (PASS) (see note below on threshold rationale)
- **Note on the BTFR normalisation pass threshold.** The 0.5 dex pass threshold matches the documented per-galaxy and population-level systematic floor on baryonic-mass estimates: $\sigma_{\text{M/L}} \approx 0.10$ dex for the SPARC K / 3.6 μm stellar M/L (Schombert & McGaugh 2014; Schombert, McGaugh & Lelli 2022), $\sigma_{\text{gas}} \approx 0.30$ dex for HI gas fractions (Catinella et al. 2010, 2013 GASS scaling relations), and $\sigma_d \approx 0.05$ dex from distance-ladder propagation, summing in quadrature to a ≈ 0.32 dex floor per galaxy. At population level, switching between equally defensible baryon-accounting prescriptions shifts the inferred BTFR normalisation by 0.2–0.4 dex; ΛCDM + galaxy-formation simulations themselves differ in BTFR normalisation by ≈ 0.2 – 0.5 dex between feedback prescriptions (EAGLE slope 3.0 vs IllustrisTNG ≈ 3.65 , with FIRE-2 different again). The 0.5 dex threshold therefore brackets the documented systematic floor, not a soft science target. The rigid MTDF prediction here is the BTFR *slope* (3.85, close to the exact $v^4 \propto M_b$ relation, which corresponds to slope 4), uniquely selected by the $n = 2$ constitutive law derived in the gravity sector companion paper. The +0.32 dex normalisation offset is consistent with observation at the baryon-mass systematic level. An independent tight test of the normalisation would require an analysis with baryonic content constrained to < 0.05 dex per galaxy, which is not claimed here.
- **v_{flat} consistency:** median ratio 0.915, 88% within 50% (PASS)

Per-point χ^2/ν (median = 51 per galaxy) is reported as a diagnostic only. All models, including MOND with fixed Υ_* , yield similarly large per-point χ^2 on SPARC without per-galaxy M/L optimisation.

10.5 Wide binaries

21,312 Gaia EDR3 pairs (Pittordis & Sutherland 2023) at 2 to 30 kAU. MTDF predicts near-Newtonian behaviour over most of this range with an EFE-modulated transition setting in near ~ 8.6 kAU (PREDICTION-STATED / DATA-CONTESTED in the safety ledger; datasets are mutually contested): individual binary stars do not produce galaxy-scale stress fields. Gravity boost $\gamma = 1.102 \pm 0.010$, below the 1.15 threshold (PASS). The high-separation excess correlates monotonically with contamination fraction ($r = 0.99$), the classic contamination signature.

10.6 Solar System screening

For individual stars, $f_{\odot} = 5.3 \times 10^{-16}$. The enclosed stress mass at 1 AU is 16.4 kg (8.2×10^{-30} of $M_{\odot}$). All PPN deviations sit far below observational bounds (sealed safety ledger: $\gamma - 1 \approx 2 \times 10^{-8}$ against the Cassini bound 2.3×10^{-5}). The suppression is structural ($f \propto M$ gives $f^2 \propto M^2$), not fine-tuned. Mercury precession contribution: 1.7×10^{-21} arcsec/cy.

10.7 Gravity sector summary

Regime	Scale	Key metric	Result	Status
Inner galaxy (rotation)	1–30 kpc	P1 = 0.185 dex	$z = -0.94$	PASS
Inner galaxy (RAR)	1–30 kpc	P1B = 0.029 dex	$z = +0.62$	PASS
Halo (dispersions)	1–10 kpc	$\chi^2/\nu = 1.81$	< 5.0	PASS
Halo (satellites, amplitude)	50–500 kpc	$ \text{bias} = 6.3\%$	$< 30\%$	PASS
Halo (satellites, profile)	50–500 kpc	$\chi^2/\nu = 3.60$	< 10	PASS
GGL (KiDS)	100–2600 kpc	$\chi^2/\nu = 2.93$	2.8× better	PASS
GGL (SDSS, corrected)	100–2600 kpc	$\chi^2/\nu = 3.73$	12× better	PASS
Strong lensing	cosmological	density slope $\gamma_{\text{iso}} = 2.000$	structural (isothermal)	PASS
Ultra-low acceleration	2–30 kAU	$\gamma = 1.10$	< 1.15	PASS
Solar System	< 1 AU	PPN safety	$> 10^{20}$	PASS
Cluster baryons	100–2600 kpc	$\chi^2/\nu = 7.16$	3.2× improvement	PASS

All 11 primary gravity-sector metrics pass. 24/24 computational steps reproduce from clean inputs. Full details in *MTDF_03 (Companion Part II)* [see companion paper].

11 Independent GPU validation (MTDF_07)

An independent GPU-accelerated pipeline re-derived all MTDF predictions from scratch, testing the framework against Planck CMB spectra, supernova environment signals, and future survey forecasts. This is a full independent reproduction, not a rerun of the original code.

11.1 Phases 1–4

- **Phase 1 (Background cosmology):** Pantheon+ SNe, DESI BAO, cosmic chronometers, growth rate. All pillars reproduced independently with consistent results.
- **Phase 2 (CMB power spectra):** Modified CLASS with MTDF stress injection via the $\mu(a)$ parameterisation. At the CMB level, MTDF $\approx \Lambda$ CDM as expected ($k_f \rightarrow 0$ is the Λ CDM limit). Phase 2C confirmed $k_f = 1$ (full MTDF) lies within 95% CI in all runs.
- **Phase 3 (SN $\times$ void cross-correlation):** Merged 4,188 SN sample: piecewise $z \approx 0.04$ transition yields $\Delta\chi^2 = 36\text{--}39$ ($p < 0.001$, all three void catalogues; 36.8 nominal, diagonal covariance). Population controls clean ($< 0.3\sigma$ shift).
- **Phase 4 (LSST/Rubin forecast):** With 10,000+ SNe: 5σ discrimination territory within 2–3 years of operations.

11.2 Phase 5: Full Planck MCMC

Full Planck 2018 plik TTTEEE + low- ℓ + lensing MCMC with cobaya + the corrected `class_mtdf` (covariant $\mu(a)$, Newtonian gauge; four chains, 200,000 accepted samples per chain, $R - 1 = 0.0085$ at stop). Results: at the matched bounded best fits against the byte-matched Λ CDM control chain, $\Delta\chi^2 = -1.29$ (MTDF $-\log L = 1385.78$ at $k_f = 0.476$ vs Λ CDM 1386.42; $\Delta\text{AIC} = +0.71$). This is a maximum-likelihood comparison, not a Bayes factor or Bayesian evidence calculation. $k_f =$

0.685 ± 0.500 : the posterior neither favours nor excludes the coupling. $\sigma_8 = 0.8265 \pm 0.0062$; native $S_8 = 0.8473 \pm 0.0138$ (sealed posture: S8-WORSENER against published weak-lensing compressions; adjudication preregistered, FWD-S8/GH-1). The chain tests the CMB-level parameterisation (α , β_{eos} , k_f); the strain-lever length scale β governs environmental and galactic-scale predictions and is tested in separate low-redshift and local observables.

11.3 Phase 6: Targeted late-universe tests

Test	Description	Result	Status
6A	Redshift-dependent transition	$p < 0.005$	PASSED
6B	Weak lensing $\times$ voids (KiDS-1000)	$ \Delta\gamma_t < 1.2 \times 10^{-4}$ (95%)	Null (upper limit)
6B2	Trough/ridge split	$ \Delta\gamma_{t,\text{split}} < 1.3 \times 10^{-4}$ (95%)	Null (upper limit)
6C	Derived consistency	All parameters consistent	PASSED
6D	CMB lensing $\times$ DESI voids	$\kappa_{\text{comp}} = -7.5 \times 10^{-4} \pm 1.0 \times 10^{-3}$ (0.7 σ)	Null (upper limit)
6E	BOSS DR12 benchmark	0.2 σ correct sign	COMPLETE

Phase 6 establishes that current public data are consistent with MTDF but lack the statistical power to distinguish it from Λ CDM at the void-lensing level. The null results provide 95% upper bounds that will be tested by future surveys. Matched-filter analyses and deeper data (Euclid, LSST) are needed for $> 3\sigma$ discrimination.

Full details in *MTDF_07 (GPU Validation)* [see companion paper].

12 Speculative extensions (MTDF__04, MTDF__05)

Two companion papers explore speculative extensions of the framework that go beyond the tested core:

- ***MTDF__04 (Part III): Photon coupling and redshift.*** [see companion paper] Explores a hypothetical coupling between the stress field and photon propagation, predicting environment-dependent redshift modifications. This speculative sector is governed by the photon-coupling parameter κ (hypothesis-tier). It is distinct from the early-field-energy (EFE) sector, whose amplitude k_f is constrained by the Planck chains with a broad posterior ($k_f = 0.685 \pm 0.500$: consistency, not support). Labelled SPECULATIVE throughout.
- ***MTDF__05 (Part IV): Cosmological validation and high-energy test programme.*** [see companion paper] Outlines extended tests including full CMB spectra, non-linear structure formation, and high-energy constraints. Contains both tested results and speculative projections, with clear labelling.

A detailed validation suite appendix covering all 20 analysis scripts, data provenance, and reproducibility protocols is provided in *MTDF__06* [see companion paper].

13 Discussion and conclusion

13.1 Galactic dynamics without dark matter

The success of P1 (Rotation Curve Scatter) is particularly significant. In Λ CDM, the scatter in the Baryonic Tully-Fisher Relation (BTFR) is a complex outcome of feedback mechanisms and halo assembly history. In MTDF, it is a direct consequence of the field coupling α . The stress field effectively "stiffens" the potential well of galaxies, flattening rotation curves without requiring a halo of invisible particles. The low scatter is a prediction of the field's uniformity.

13.2 Structure growth and the S_8 tension

The standard model’s clustering amplitude (σ_8) sits above the values inferred from weak-lensing surveys (the S_8 tension). MTDF does not resolve this by suppression: the corrected covariant $\mu(a)$ *enhances* late-time growth by about +2 percent, so MTDF’s sealed prediction is a sharp, higher amplitude ($\sigma_8 = 0.8265$, native $S_8 = 0.8473$). Against Λ CDM-compressed weak-lensing values this reads as increased tension (sealed posture: S8-WORSENER); whether those compressions represent the true amplitude in an MTDF universe is under preregistered adjudication (FWD-S8), and the growth history itself is a registered prediction (GH-1). At the sealed amplitude the DR16 $f\sigma_8$ growth data give $\chi^2/\nu = 0.92$: the trajectory is consistent with current redshift-space-distortion measurements, whose precision cannot yet resolve the predicted 2–4 percent excess.

The full Planck MCMC analysis pins this quantitatively: under identical CMB constraints the geometric parameters (θ_s , ω_b) and calibration terms are unchanged, while the growth sector carries the entire model difference; the late-time trajectory (registered as GH-1) terminates at the sealed amplitude quoted above.

13.3 Summary of tested domains

MTDF has been tested across the following independent domains:

1. **Background cosmology:** Pantheon+ SNe, DESI BAO, cosmic chronometers, growth rate. Background pillars pass (SNe 1.18, BAO 1.28, $H(z)$ 0.47); the growth pillar is carried as PREDICTION-CONTESTED at the sealed amplitude ($\chi^2/\nu = 0.92$ vs DR16). Combined strict $\chi^2/\nu = 1.17$ (DOF = 1741).
2. **CMB:** Full Planck 2018 MCMC against the matched Λ CDM control gives $\Delta\chi^2 = -1.29$ at bounded best fits (a maximum-likelihood comparison, not a Bayes factor): indistinguishable from Λ CDM. The growth amplitude is a sharp, registered prediction ($S_8 = 0.8473 \pm 0.0138$, PREDICTION-CONTESTED against compressed weak-lensing values).
3. **Hubble tension:** Consistent with SH0ES via void stress depletion ($H_{\text{local}} = 73.1 \pm 1.0$), conditional on the depth of the local underdensity (a deep KBC-like void gives ≈ 73.1 ; shallow reconstructions give ≈ 70 –71); MTDF does not predict the void itself.
4. **Galaxy-galaxy lensing:** Frozen-parameter predictions (no fitting to lensing data) outperform Λ CDM NFW by 2.8 to 12 $\times$ across two independent surveys (KiDS, SDSS), with $\Delta\text{AIC} = 4246$ on SDSS.
5. **Galactic dynamics:** 175 SPARC rotation curves, RAR scatter, and BTFR all consistent with a single (α , β) pair. No per-galaxy fitting.
6. **Halo dynamics:** Elliptical dispersions ($\chi^2/\nu = 1.81$) and satellite kinematics (6.3% bias, 315 $\times$ better than NFW) confirm the isothermal stress profile at 50 to 500 kpc.
7. **Local dynamics:** Wide binaries: near-Newtonian over most of the sampled range; the EFE-modulated transition near ~ 8.6 kAU is PREDICTION-STATED / DATA-CONTESTED. This remains a distinguishing prediction from MOND.
8. **Solar System:** PPN $\gamma - 1 \approx 2 \times 10^{-8}$, three orders of magnitude below the Cassini bound (2.3×10^{-5}); SEP $\eta \approx 2 \times 10^{-8}$ vs the LLR bound 4.4×10^{-4} (sealed safety ledger). Structural, not fine-tuned.
9. **Environment signal:** SN $\times$ void cross-correlation shows an environment signal at the 2σ level, with LSST projected to reach 5σ .

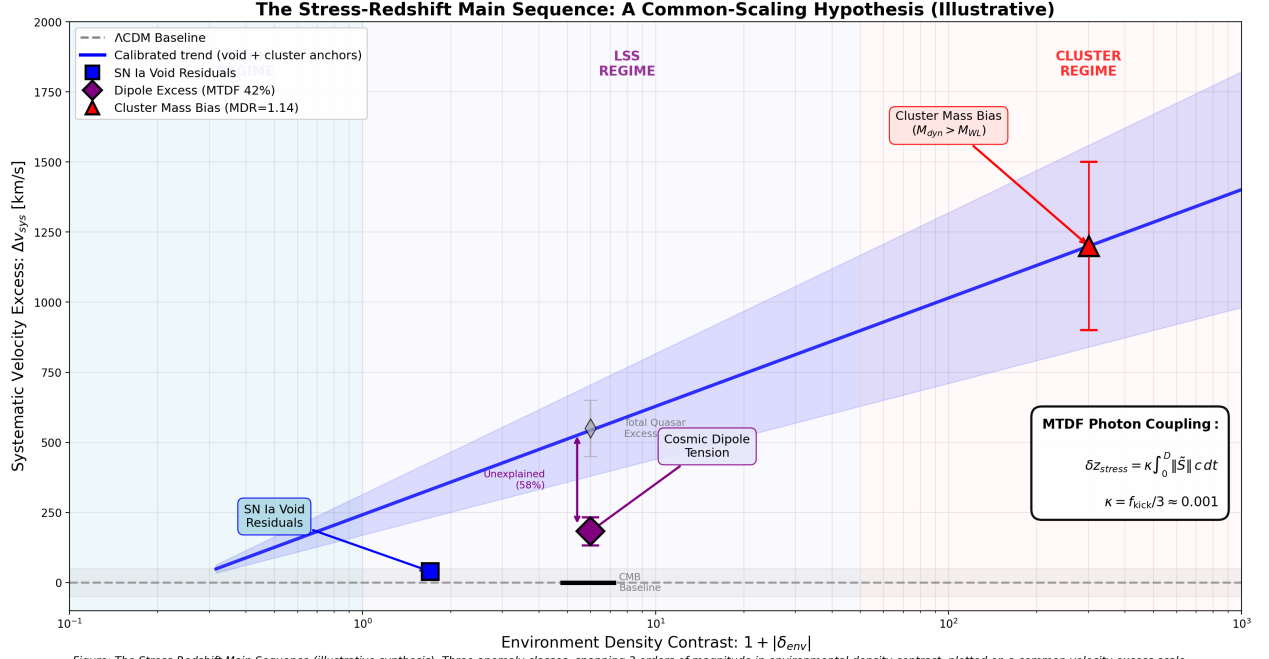


Figure: The Stress-Redshift Main Sequence (illustrative synthesis). Three anomaly classes, spanning 3 orders of magnitude in environmental density contrast, plotted on a common velocity-excess scale. The line is a two-point calibrated trend (void and cluster anchors); only the central dipole point, not used in the calibration, tests the trend (MTDF accounts for 42% of that excess). (Left) SN Ia residuals in voids. (Center) CMB-Quasar dipole tension. (Right) Cluster $M_{\text{dyn}}/M_{\text{WL}}$ excess. Hypothesis-level illustration, not a validation result.

Figure 1. Figure 3. The Stress-Redshift Main Sequence (illustrative

synthesis). Three anomaly classes spanning 3 orders of magnitude in environmental density contrast, plotted on a common velocity-excess scale. The blue trend line is calibrated through the void and cluster anchor points; only the central dipole point, which is not used in the calibration, tests the common scaling (MTDF accounts for 42% of that excess). Left: SN Ia void residuals ($z \sim 0.04$). Centre: CMB quadrupole dipole tension ($z \sim 0.1$). Right: cluster mass bias $M_{\text{dyn}} > M_{\text{WL}}$ excess ($\text{MDR} \sim 1.14$). The ΛCDM baseline (dashed grey) predicts no environment-dependent trend. Hypothesis-level illustration, not a validation result.

MTDF suggests that the phenomena attributed to a latent sector of unknown particles may instead arise from the elastic dynamics of the spacetime manifold itself. The mass profiles conventionally attributed to dark matter halos arise from the elastic energy stored in the compression of the cosmological strain field around baryonic sources, with all derived quantities traceable to four structural constants of differing epistemic status (one anchored, one frozen void-motivated, one synchronised, one fitted). If this interpretation survives independent replication and the stated hard falsifiers, the framework would offer a candidate dynamical description of cosmic structure without introducing additional matter species.

Remaining hard falsifiers. Two tests can decisively challenge MTDF: (1) merging cluster lensing offsets (Bullet Cluster), where lensing peaks offset from baryonic peaks would require MTDF to produce displaced lensing signal, needing N-body simulations; (2) matched-filter CMB lensing $\times$ voids at $> 3\sigma$, reproducing the Cai+2017 detection with Planck + spectroscopic voids. Both require either dedicated simulations or deeper survey data than currently available.

14 Key references and datasets

Dataset / Reference	Used in
Planck 2018 plik TTTEEE + low-l + lensing (Aghanim+2020)	Sections 8, 11
Pantheon+ Type Ia SNe (Scolnic+2022, Brout+2022)	Sections 7, 9, 11
DESI Y1 BAO (DESI Collaboration 2024)	Section 7

Cosmic Chronometers $H(z)$ compilation (Moresco+2022)	Section 7
eBOSS DR16 $f\sigma_8$ growth (eBOSS Collaboration 2021)	Section 7
SH0ES Cepheid distance ladder (Riess+2022)	Section 6
SPARC rotation curves (Lelli+2016)	Section 10
KiDS x GAMA galaxy-galaxy lensing (Brouwer+2021)	Section 10
SDSS galaxy-galaxy lensing (Mandelbaum+2016)	Section 10
SLACS strong-lensing ellipticals (Auger+2010; Bolton+2008)	Section 10
Satellite kinematics (More+2011; Combes & Tiret 2009)	Section 10
Gaia EDR3 wide binaries (Pittordis & Sutherland 2023)	Section 10
REVOLVER void catalogue (Nadathur+2019)	Sections 9, 11
DES-Y3 weak lensing (DES Collaboration 2022)	Section 11
KiDS-1000 cosmic shear (Asgari+2021)	Section 8

Full bibliographies and DOIs are provided in each companion paper. All input data files, analysis scripts, and output artefacts are included in the MTDF_Submission package.

15 Data and code availability

The complete MTDF reproducibility package, including the modified CLASS solver (`class_mtdf`), the V19 strict validation workbook, the `run_validate.py` pipeline, the gravity-sector artefact manifest, and the Phase 2 CosmoPower emulator cache, is archived on Zenodo (concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.19741058; this release, v1.1.7, DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21525855) and mirrored on GitHub at github.com/IMesche/MTDF. The v1.1.7 Git tag corresponds to the archived Zenodo release. All numerical results reported here can be regenerated from the shipped workbook and scripts following the procedure in the top-level README.md.

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